

a boon, freely given

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by [Iriascend](#)

Summary

Jason has been getting boon after boon, blessing after blessing from — he assumes — the Fae all his life. He worries what kind of debt he's accrued.

Notes

This is a campfire (a story told 'live') I've held on a JayTim discord server. It reached frankly bonkers length for a campfire, so I decided to post it. Enjoy!

See the end of the work for [more notes](#)

It all starts, as all things do in life, with his mother. She tells him about the tooth fairy when Jason's first tooth gets loose. He gets very excited about the prospect of having his own money, however little it may be. A tooth for a handful of change feels like a good deal, and it sets the precedent for Jason's interaction with the Fae — even if this time, it's his mom who plays the Fae part. When he's a little older and sees his mom worry about money and groceries, he puts a lock of his hair under his pillow, hoping the Fae trade in other body parts than just teeth. They do, and the next day Jason happily gives the extra 10 dollars to his mom. Catherine doesn't believe in fairy tales, not anymore, so she doesn't listen to Jason's explanation of where he got the money. Eventually, she just makes him promise that he will not steal or get himself in trouble to get money. Still, she's not going to say no to money that's already there; she doesn't have the comfort to refuse it.

Over the years, Jason starts relying on the Fae whenever his family is a little down on luck. All his milk teeth and a couple curls of his hair get bartered off. When he runs out of teeth, he tries offering his toys. The Fae aren't fond of the action figures, but they do buy his favourite plushie for a whooping 50 bucks. He misses it dearly, because he's had the teddy ever since he remembers (and it was his only plushie), but the money gets them through the week. Catherine stops questioning where Jason gets the money at some point. She can't stop him nor save him, apparently. She just hopes he's got better luck than his dad.

Jason gets into a habit of talking into the void whenever he offers something for sale, and even starts trying to haggle the deals. He leaves things under his pillow, or out by the window (they have to get in somehow, do they not?) and loudly states how much he thinks it is worth. Sometimes he gets the price. Sometimes he gets a little less. Sometimes he tried once or twice again, offering a smaller price. He never asks for fun money. Only when they really need it. Partially because he actually likes his stuff and would rather keep it. Partially because he's seen people get reliant on pawn shops and this feels strangely similar.

When his father goes to jail for the first time, it feels natural to ask the Fae for help. They've been good business partners so far. He isn't stupid enough to think he has anything he can trade in for enough money to bail dad out, but he still has to do *something*. Instead, he leaves half of his lunch out on the windowsill hoping it will at the very least attract their attention, and since it's not a direct trade — leaves a note asking if they could do him a favour for an IOU. He promises to pay it off somehow. He tells them they can take anything they want that is his, if they think it'll pay. Jason's lunchbox is empty in the morning and while Willis is still convinced in the following week, half the evidence against him goes suddenly missing and the sentence is considerably lower than they expected.

It must make Willis feel like he's under a lucky star, because when he gets out, he goes straight back to his old ways. He gets caught, but he's sure that it will again be a tiny sentence compared to what he accomplished, and thus *worth it*. But Jason knows better. For a moment, Jason thinks about going to someone else — to a loan shark who will help him bail dad out the *normal* way — but he eventually decides against it. The Fae always were just and agreeable, and never ripped him off. The loan sharks on the other hand have given his mom a lot of grey hair. He asks the Fae for another favor. And another. And another. They deliver every time. It's not always how he'd imagine it, and most people don't see anything odd about

the situations. But Jason knows what he asked for, and thus can see that it's more than coincidence when it all comes true.

Willis grows more and more *bold* in his capers, until he finally steps on someone's toes too hard. Even if he suspects the Fae might have a way to bring someone back from the dead, Jason is smarter than to ask for something he can't pay for.

That's why when his mom starts getting ill — be it from stress and malnutrition, or something else — Jason asks if the Fae can help her get better when he still knows there's good chances. If they had enough money for a good doctor, if they could afford mom's meds, everything would be fine. And it is, for a while. Mom gets better. Happier, at least. Jason simply realises way too late that the pills she's taking these days aren't painkillers anymore.

When dad died, Jason could blame the people who killed him. When mom dies, very nearly in his arms, he doesn't have that clear-cut target for his anger. So he chooses the next best thing — the Fae. Blames them for how expensive the doctors were, for how little they could do for mom. Blames them for letting her spend the medicine money on drugs. Blames them for not telling him. Blames them, because otherwise the only person he could be blaming is himself. That is how Jason Todd ends up on the street, without a pillow or a windowsill to leave offers on. Somehow, it doesn't matter.

The boons — and they are boons, Jason has had enough time and experience to be able to tell a stroke of luck or simple coincidence from the Fae's meddling — keep coming. There's not much one can do for a child on the streets of Gotham without giving him the winning lottery tickets, and they're not as good as they would've probably been if he asked for them outright, but they're *there*. He finds more food in the dumpsters than he should and finds better hiding spots and it never rains on his birthdays.

The fair folk even get as bold as to visit him, he thinks. Once or twice, when he's out trying to pick pockets or panhandling in the better parts of Gotham, he runs into... not quite humans. Humans slightly to the left, you could say. Fully human at a glance, but if you ever pay them more attention, there's just... they don't move quite right, their skin is just a little too smooth and maybe they have a couple too many teeth (is that where his milk teeth went?). Sure, it could be just *Gotham*, but given his history, he honestly thinks it's the Fae.

He's trying to catch one of them — tell them to stop giving him things he can't pay for, he didn't sign up for this amount of magical debt, dammit! — when he runs into the Batmobile in a back alley. And, listen. Yes, *having a talk* with his Fae benefactor is very important and this is most definitely a bait and switch, but can a kid like him *pass* the opportunity to nick the wheels off of the goddamn Batmobile? No. No he can't.

For a while Jason is very suspicious of the Batman. Cryptids lay very close to the fairies if you ask him. This could just as well be a kidnapping attempt. A very late changeling schtick. And Jason's not going behind the veil without putting up a fight. But Batman breathes and bleeds just like humans do, and the burger he gets him is very human, also. But then Batman

tempts him with a prospect of a warm bath and a dry bed, well, in the cold autumn air of Gotham Bay... it's working. Though he's learned that even humans can be nasty to have debts with, especially when you're already probably sold your soul or something. If nothing else, Jason's learned to never agree to deals on IOUs, and he definitely doesn't believe in good will and charity. He agrees to exchange the three wheels he's already managed to steal for a bed and breakfast (it's more than he could pawn them for, anyway).

Wayne Manor's food might as well be Faerie food the way he knows he will never be able to go back to eating out of dumpsters after eating from Mr. Alfred's kitchen.

(It's not that he doesn't love chili dogs, he really does, but... it's been a while since he ate out of a clean, *ceramic* plate, you know? Back when dad was still sometimes home, and mom had time and money to cook)

When morning comes, he's once again half-convinced that Bruce Wayne is some kind of fair folk, because he's faced with another offer. (Wayne, in contrast to his previous 'benefactor', at least has the decency to hash out his deals and offer to haggle instead of giving boons regardless of whenever Jason wants them or not, driving him deeper and deeper into debt) He refuses, of course, to stay 'for free'. He knows nothing is free in this world. But he does agree to stay as a... the right word is probably "servant", especially in the context of how fabulously wealthy Waynes are but that sounds awful. The point is, it's not a deal. It's a proper job. With a contract, even. A bed and three square meals as payment, much like Mr Alfred has, and clear-cut duties: daily dusting and sweeping the floors, doing the dishes and helping with carrying stuff around as needed. He can do that. That is fair and that can easily be terminated without any strings attached to it. Mom would've never believed he got a proper job, without even finishing school.

(It never occurs to him that maybe minors without proper state-issued IDs aren't capable of forming legally-binding contracts and maybe Bruce is just indulging his demands so that he feels safer)

And if he... grows fond of Mr Alfred over time, and helps more than he's contractually required to... well, that is his private matters. And if Mr Alfred acts like he doesn't notice when Jason steals snacks out of the kitchen, well, that's between them. And if he doesn't quite mind when Wayne looks up from his newspaper (or report or whatever CEOs read in the evenings) and offers tips and advice on his maths homework... well, that's just how it is.

And if I am to gloss over how Jason becomes Robin, because I frankly do not remember the canon and it doesn't matter anyway, then hopefully you, the reader, will forgive me.

The important takeaway from this is, Jason no longer has any *need* (he didn't have the *desire* ever since mom passed away) to ask the Fae for any favors, nor the Fae have many — if any — opportunities to bless him without warning. Not in his private life, at least. Bruce makes sure that his son has all that he would ever need, after all. Robin sometimes needs a bit of

luck, a hunch of where to look or an improbable landing going smoothly. He tries to ignore those. He trains very hard to never need those either.

No amount of endurance runs in the world can train the compassion out of his heart, though, nor the curiosity out of his mind. When he hears that maybe he still has family in this world — nothing can stop him from looking for her.

(It never occurs to him that he's already had a family all these years)

That is how he ends up in Ethiopia. That is how he ends up trying to save the woman who was supposed to love him. That is how he suffers, again, for his charity (he really should've learned by now, he thinks as the smoke fills his nose).

But this time — in this world — something goes different. In this world, Lady Luck isn't against him. There's no narrator to hate him, there is no audience to viciously call for his end. Instead, there's... a boon.

This time, Jason will admit, he asked for it. For the first time since his childhood, he doesn't want to die. He doesn't call out though, not out loud at least. By that point it is hard to talk. But in the depths of his soul, in his heart of hearts, he wishes: save me. I am not dead, not just yet. This is not beyond your power. Half-sarcastically, he argues — who are you going to cash in all the IOUs on if I die here? Save me. Save me, please.

Bruce finds him in a bed of flowers instead of a pile of rubble, surrounded by a thick dome of greens. They are like a beacon among the destruction. The smell is sweet and overwhelming. The branches and vines are singed from the explosion, broken by the blast, barely holding up, and yet — they stand, keep the danger at bay. When Bruce looks more closely, they seem to wobble slightly; like they're struggling, like they're sentient and consciously making an effort.

Bruce thinks he might have to re-examine how Jason called him one of the fair gentry back in the day.

The plants part when he approaches his Robin — his *son* — and fall down as if breathing out in relief. Inside, Jason is badly hurt, but breathing, too. In this world, Lady Luck spares him.

It takes time, but Jason recovers.

And when he does, Bruce asks him about the Fae. Bruce explains what he found, what saved Jason. Because if Jason is one of the Fae, he's involved with magic of some kind, he'd like to at least know. Jason panics. His Fae benefactor saved him. Saved his life. He has asked for the most expensive favor in existence — at least according to all the Fae lore he's read — in exchange for another IOU. He might as well be owned by the Fae at this point. Bruce isn't quite convinced. There's definitely something weird going on, though (he's not going to believe in fairies without a little more proof), so he decides to ask for an expert opinion. Jason, left to calm down and rest some more, decides he should probably save the effort and

ask to be taken immediately (it's how this is going to end, right? there's no way he's *not* going to end up as a servant in a Faerie court of some kind)

Just when B leaves, there's a knock on the window. Jason doesn't startle, because Dickhead sometimes likes to climb the outside walls out of boredom, but this time it's not him. It's a boy roughly his age, sitting on the windowsill and waving at him. The boy has hair as black as ebony and skin as fair as snow, and way too many teeth in the grin he gives Jason.

Jason opens the window. "Can I come in?" the boy asks.

"... yeah."

Another toothy grin. It gives Jason the chills the way he thinks a rabbit feels about the eagle, even if there's nothing explicitly malicious or menacing in that smile.

The boy hops inside and stretches. "I'm so happy you finally invited me properly," he says, looking around. His accent is odd, maybe slightly British, but otherwise just... slightly to the left. Like he hasn't quite grasped how to speak the ways humans do.

Jason frowns. "Pretty sure I've asked to talk to your lot many times before."

"Oh, no, you screamed for me to, and I quote, *show myself*. And I did. But you've never asked to actually talk to me."

Jason sighs. He would say that's what he's always meant, but he knows better than to argue semantics with the Fae. "Okay, so what do you want?" Jason snaps instead. The boy sits on his bed and inspects the linens. They must be up to his standards, because he nods to himself before falling back and stretching out on the bed like a cat.

"Why would I want anything?" he asks.

"You saved my life!"

The boy sits up on his elbows, looking a little confused. "Was that not enough?" he asks. His tone is... concerned.

The boy looks up, frowning, like he's calculating.

"What do you mean, not enough? I—" Jason starts, but is interrupted.

"I'm not very old. It took a bit out of me to do that. I didn't have enough power to help you heal. Even now, it's not easy to cross the veil for me." He stands up and pretends to dust his clothes. Only now does Jason realise that for a Fae, the boy is wildly underdressed in a band t-shirt and ripped jeans. "But if you're not satisfied, I do suppose we're not even quite just yet."

"What the fuck are you on about?"

There's good thirty seconds of silence between them. Jason stares intently at the Fae boy, wholeheartedly confused. The boy stares back.

"You *must* realise that we, the Fae, do not exactly vibe with the concept of charity," the boy says, looking him up and down with suspicion.

"Yes, I know that. That's what confuses me. I've been asking for shit all my life and even when I've hadn't, you've been giving me shit left and right—" he cuts himself off. "It was you, right? I'm talking to the right guy?"

"I am not aware of any debts you have to anyone else of my kind," the boy answers. Jason notes that it's not a definitive *no*, but he guesses that it might just be lack of knowledge rather than trying to lie through his teeth. "But you're correct in thinking that I've been granting you boons for some time now."

There's another lengthy pause. Jason finally realises the Fae will not say anything more without prodding.

"Okay, let me get this straight. You've been giving me things, yes?"

"Correct."

"The Fae do not give anything for free. Yes?"

"Mmmm— debatable. Define 'free'."

"You always do trades. This for that. Deals."

"Oh, yes, in that sense. We're honor-bound to return all and any graces we've received, and in turn, all things are honor-bound to return any boons we grant."

"See, this is where I'm not following. You said you don't want anything from me, even though you've been giving me stuff all my life."

"Exactly. I'm not keen on making my debt to you any bigger."

Jason loses a beat. "Your what now?"

"My debt to you."

"I'm the one indebted to you."

They stand there for a second before it clicks into place in their minds. When it does, they point at each other, eyes wide. "YOU THOUGHT IT'S THE OTHER WAY ROUND?!"

"*NO* self-respecting Fae does blind trades," the boy shrieks, as if the mere *thought* that he'd give hand-outs is offending to him. "And those who do accept IOUs are very picky who they deal with! Kings, legends! Heroes! You have to be *special* for the gentry to take the risk!"

"Well *excuse me* for not being a magical fucking noble!"

"That's not what I—" the boy screeches in frustration. "Granting a boon is *costly*. Even life-threatening, at times. To not receive immediate payment means you're making an investment

that might not pay back, so the deal has to be *extra* sweet for anyone to consider it."

"Okay, fine! Whatever." Jason takes a deep breath. This makes sense (some, at least) and as far as he remembers the Fae can't lie, but it's all new and he's still high-strung and he's not thinking very clearly. Not a good thing when you're talking to the fair folk, so he attempts to calm himself down. "Why would you have a debt to me, though? We've never met before."

"Oh, we did."

"Where?"

"In Gotham." Jason frowns. That's avoidance if he ever saw any.

"When?"

The boy looks away. "In the past."

"When *exactly*?"

The boy starts twirling his fingers. "On a Thursday."

"When *precisely*?"

The boy turns red. "Is this an investigation? Shouldn't I get an attorney?"

"Just answer the questions."

"I have the right to remain silent."

"No you don't."

The boy opens his mouth, then slaps his hands over it. After a moment of struggle, he makes another frustrated screech and speaks up again.

"That was mean. You can't just throw words around like that, it's very impolite and—"

Jason eyes him for a moment. "... Answer my last question."

The boy sends him a nasty glare.

"On Thursday, 24th, at thirty past five in the evening, 12 years ago."

Jason frowns. "I was like... five at the time."

"Yes. So was I, in human equivalent."

"I don't remember meeting a Fae. Nor doing anything that would warrant this—" he waves around to gesture to the entirety of the situation, "—loyalty."

"But I do."

"And you don't want to tell me, for some reason."

"It's... embarrassing."

"Everything two five-year-olds would do is embarrassing."

"No, I mean—... it's in poor taste for a Fae to have this kind of commitment, especially from such a young age."

It is Jason's turn to make a frustrated sound. His is more of a groan, though. "I'm going to go insane with all the secrets."

"Well, the good news is, now that we've talked and cleared this out, you can just ask for something big enough and it'll be sorted."

"And if I don't?"

The boy's face drops suddenly. "I would continue to grant you boons where I see fit in hopes that one day I'll be free."

Jason's eyebrows shoot high. "What do you mean, free? Shouldn't it be on me to collect the debt?"

"I—... *technically*."

"Can't you go fuck off wherever you please until I need you or something?"

"Not with this kind of deal."

Now that Jason knows he's not getting screwed over (for once), it would be dumb to throw the aid of a Fae away. It's practically free magic. But... It seems that however this damned deal came to be, it is very upsetting to the Fae. It feels... wrong, to reap the rewards of something he didn't even do consciously.

"Well, what if I say you're good? Does that settle it?"

"That's not how it works. This for that, remember?"

"Well, then how big of a thing I need to wish for?"

"I... don't know," the boy admits in confusion. "I would just... feel it in the moment. Appraisal of boons is actually a very difficult skill that we hone over a lifetime and, well, as I said. I am not very old."

"And saving my life didn't do it?" Jason asks to make sure.

The boy shakes his head. "I'm hoping it is at the very least more than halfway there, though."

"Well, then we might have to get acquainted until I get almost killed again," he says, grinning, then extends his arm towards the boy. "My name's—"

"NO!" The boy slaps his hands over Jason's mouth. "Don't give me your name. That would give me leverage over you."

"... don't you guys usually want that? I mean, it feels like you could use that to barter it back for some of your debt or something."

The boy shrugs and goes red on the cheeks, again. Jason considers it for a moment. "You can call me Jay, then. Is this okay?"

"Yeah. That's how we usually do it."

"Can humans do stuff with Fae names, too?"

"Sometimes. If they know how."

"Okay so, how do I call you?"

"My name's Timothy."

Jason frowns. "Didn't you just say not to—"

"You already have way more than my name."

"What the fuck can I have that is worth more than a life and gives me more leverage over you than your name?!"

Timothy doesn't answer. There silence between them is so thick one could cut it with a knife.

Finally, he mumbles something, red as a beet. "My heart."

"Come again?"

"MY HEART!" he screams suddenly, like something finally snapped in him. "I showed you my heart, and then it was gone. I never got anything in return so you must've stolen it. Mother said so too! You stole my heart! And I don't know how to get it back!"

Jason frowns. "How the fuck could I steal a heart?"

Somehow, Timothy goes even redder. "I— We met in a playground when I accidentally went through the veil. And you... You were nice and took care of me and helped me until my parents found me. And I told you all about myself when we played together, and ever since, there's nothing on my mind except for you. I can't think straight, I can't even do magic properly! If I don't get my heart back I'll never be a proper prince."

"There is so much to unpack there I don't even know where to begin."

"I knew I shouldn't have came," Timothy mumbles to himself, starting to frantically pace around the room. In doing so, he loses the air of danger and mystery. Like that, he looks like any other boy, and Jason can imagine that if he saw him panicking on a playground, he'd try to help. "I should've tried stealing it back when you were out, like mom said—"

"Well, that wouldn't have worked," Jason notes.

Tim — because he's definitely not *Timothy* anymore, not like that — once again looks offended. "And why not?!"

"Because I don't have it."

Tim blinks. "What?"

"Your heart isn't here."

"Where *else* would it be?"

Jason makes a non-committal noise and shrugs. "You tell me."

Tim's eyes go wide with panic again. "Did you—... did you lose it? *Did you sell it off to someone else?*"

"No, I just never had it. Not in the way you think, I mean."

"I... don't understand."

"Timmy," Jason starts, and Tim puffs his cheeks at the indignation, "I never stole your heart. I don't think it's even possible. *To steal someone's heart* is a metaphor. I think you just..." Jason blushes slightly himself. How does one say that without sounding condescending? He doesn't think he can. "I think you just fell in love with me?" he tries.

Tim looks at him for a moment, processing, then frowns. "No, definitely not. You're a human."

"Wow. Racist much?"

"No! It's not like that. I just— I mean— Fae and humans don't—" Tim starts, turning red once again. "We don't *do* that. "

"Why so?"

"Because— I—... we—... We just— don't! We can't!"

Jason smirks. "Your mother told you that, didn't she."

"YEAH!" Tim exclaims like he suddenly has an argument again. "And mom would *never* lie to me. I mean, she *can't*, but she also would NEVER."

"Mm. See this is where I think your mom, who is older than you, simply has a better grasp on how much she can say without it *technically* being a lie. "

"I would *still* never—" he stammers a bit, seemingly not quite ready to say "fall in love with you". "I'd never— it's not— we can't—"

"Listen, Tim, I'm not gonna win the fight against your mom's words and whatever else is currently spiraling around your head, but I can assure you, I've never taken anything from you. I don't have your heart, not physically. If I have it in some magical way, you hereby have my permission to take it away from me. I won't resist."

Tim stares at him for a good thirty seconds before screeching in frustration once again.

"How do I make it stop, then?!" he calls out, and it sounds like a desperate plea. "If I don't— If I can't—... I'll never be— How do I stop thinking about you? How do I regain control over myself?"

"Well. I have an idea."

Tim looks up at him with hope.

"Stay around."

"How the hell is *that* supposed to help me stop thinking about you?"

"You have no idea who I am, do you? You've met me once, 12 years ago."

"And through your gifts and notes."

"The point is, you have no idea who I *really* am. Who I grew up to be. You—" Jason hesitates for a moment. "You love your memory of me. If you stay around and get to know the real me, you might just cure your little obsession."

Tim ponders the suggestion for a bit. "And you wouldn't... mind? Having me around?"

"At the very least, you're entertaining."

"And your family?"

Jason's silent for a moment. Then he smiles, softly. "B will have a lot of questions, but I think he'd also rather have you around than have to worry about what you're up to."

Batman isn't certainly fond of suddenly having a magical being under his roof but Jason was right — and helping Tim sort out his.... feelings is the least they can do for him saving Jason's life.

At first Tim's presence is... *unsettling*. Something about him doesn't sit quite right. Maybe it's his too many teeth and too few fingers, maybe it's how he seems to see more than they do.

Maybe it's how smooth his words are, honed to never tell a lie, but always trying to not tell the truth, either.

In time, these... fade into the background. All of Tim's oddities become... not normal per se, but they stop rousing up their prey instincts. With each day, Tim becomes more and more like

just another boy. In all the important ways, at least.

And it seems that it is the same for Tim. The first few weeks, he is visibly enamoured and intimidated by Jason's presence. Then the air of novelty fades, and all that remains is... a roommate. A friend.

They become good friends, actually. Jason tries to keep his distance at first, afraid he'll just make Tim's infatuation worse, but he's... just a human. It turns out that they both love to play pranks on other people and helping in the kitchen. Both have learned to distrust others, but are trying very hard to grow past that. Neither knows anything about the other's world, so Tim shows Jason a little bit of magic, and Jason shows Tim a little bit of technology.

Eventually, when summer ends, Tim approaches Jason with a solemn look.

"What's up?"

"The season's about to change," he says. "My mom will be back from the summer court," he adds when Jason tilts his head in confusion. "I should... be back on my side of the veil when she does."

Jason hums in agreement. He gathered that Tim's mother is a powerful being, and given how controlling she seemed, it would be unwise to make her angry.

"Are you going to keep in touch?" he asks instead.

"Of course. I'd even like to come back when I have the chance."

Jason grins. "Still not sure?" Tim's been blushing way, way less these days when Jay brings up his little crush. It's a good sign — it is what Jason had wanted, after all — but there's also a part of him that somehow... feels sad about it.

"No, I'm positive I was wrong. You didn't steal my heart 12 years ago."

Jason's eyebrows slide up. That's new. He's never said it this... openly and firmly before.

"You did it last month," Tim adds with a grin. For the first time, it is Jason who blushes.

End Notes

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